TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Different Types of Communication

The classification of communication — by medium (verbal and non-verbal), by formality, by direction within an organisation, and by the number of participants.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 3 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. Classification by medium: verbal and non-verbal

TYPE	FORMS	STRENGTHS AND LIMITS
Oral communication	Face-to-face talk, meetings, telephone, presentations, instructions on the floor	Fast, personal, immediate feedback, tone carries feeling; but leaves no record and distorts when relayed mouth to mouth.
Written communication	Letters, memos, reports, notices, email, specifications	Permanent, provable, precise, reaches many at once; but slow feedback and demands literacy and drafting skill.
Non-verbal communication	Body language — gestures, posture, facial expression, eye contact; also silence, dress, time-keeping, pictures and symbols	Continuous and often more believed than words (a claim commonly quoted: the bulk of a face-to-face message's effect is non-verbal); but ambiguous and unrecordable, and it varies by culture.

The three run together in practice: a supervisor's spoken instruction lands with its tone and gesture, and the wise communicator keeps all three channels saying the same thing — words promising safety while the eyes check the clock teach the clock's lesson, not the words'.

2. Classification by formality

- **Formal communication** flows through the organisation's official channels — the chain of command — following prescribed formats: the manager's written order, the official circular, the annual report. It is slow but authoritative and recorded.
- **Informal communication (the grapevine)** flows through social relationships — corridor talk, canteen conversation, phone friendships between departments. It is fast, spontaneous and fills the gaps the formal system leaves, but it carries rumour as readily as fact. Skilled managers neither

worship nor ban it: they feed it accurate information and listen to what it tells them about the workforce's real concerns.

3. Classification by direction (within an organisation)

DIRECTION	FLOWS BETWEEN	EXAMPLES AND PURPOSE
Downward	Superiors → subordinates	Orders, instructions, policies, targets; the largest traditional flow — and the one most often sent without feedback.
Upward	Subordinates → superiors	Reports, returns, suggestions, grievances; the organisation's eyes and ears — dies quickly if it is punished or ignored.
Horizontal (lateral)	Between equals / departments at the same level	Coordination between dyeing and finishing, production and quality; prevents each department optimising against the others.
Diagonal (crosswise)	Between different levels in different departments, skipping the chain	A quality officer dealing directly with a shift supervisor of another section — fast for cross-functional problems; used with the knowledge of the line managers it bypasses.

4. Classification by number of participants

- **Intrapersonal** — communication within oneself: thinking, planning, self-instruction (the silent half of all skilled work).
- **Interpersonal** — between two people (dyadic) or a few: conversation, interview, negotiation; the richest feedback of any type.
- **Group communication** — within a team or meeting: several senders and receivers, requiring chairing and turn-taking to stay effective.
- **Mass communication** — to large, dispersed audiences through media (press, broadcast, public notice): one-way by structure, feedback slow and statistical.

5. Choosing the type: a working rule

Match the type to the message's demands: *urgent* + *personal* → oral; *permanent* + *provable* → written; *coordination across departments* → horizontal channels opened deliberately (meetings, shared reports); *sensitive or corrective* → interpersonal and private, never mass. And in every case, add the feedback loop that Topic 2 demands — the type chosen decides how that loop is built, not whether it exists.

6. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Grapevine	The informal communication network of an organisation, running through social relationships.
Downward / upward flow	Communication from superiors to subordinates / from subordinates to superiors.
Horizontal communication	Communication between people or departments at the same organisational level.
Diagonal communication	Communication across both level and department, bypassing the direct chain.
Non-verbal communication	Communication by body language, gesture, appearance, silence and symbols, without words.
Mass communication	One-to-many communication to dispersed audiences via media.

7. Key points and summary

- By medium: oral (fast, no record), written (permanent, slower), non-verbal (continuous, ambiguous) — used together, and believed in that reverse order when they conflict.
- By formality and direction: formal channels versus the grapevine; downward, upward, horizontal and diagonal flows, each carrying different traffic.
- By participants: intrapersonal, interpersonal, group and mass — with feedback richest in the small settings and thinnest in mass communication.

8. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Classify each event by medium and by direction: (a) the managing director's written circular announcing a holiday; (b) two shift supervisors agreeing a changeover by phone; (c) a worker's

shrug in answer to a question; (d) a department head emailing production figures to the general manager.

2. State two advantages and two disadvantages of oral over written communication.
3. What is the grapevine, and why should a manager listen to it instead of trying to abolish it?
4. Give one factory example each of downward, upward, horizontal and diagonal communication.
5. A buyer complains about a late shipment. Which type(s) of communication fit the reply if the company must both apologise today and create a record for the claim file?
6. “When words and body language disagree, people believe the body language.” Explain why, using the properties of non-verbal communication.
7. Distinguish group communication from mass communication by feedback and by the roles of participants.

Answer key

1. (a) Written, downward, formal. (b) Oral, horizontal. (c) Non-verbal, upward (or interpersonal). (d) Written, upward.
2. Oral advantages: speed and immediate feedback; personal tone that motivates and clarifies. Disadvantages: no permanent record; distortion when relayed and nothing to prove in a dispute. (Written reverses both.)
3. The grapevine is the informal network carrying news through social relationships. It cannot be abolished (it is human sociability itself); it fills formal gaps, reveals workforce concerns early, and carries accurate news fastest when management feeds it facts — so the skilled manager supplies it and listens to it.
4. Downward: a production target issued to shift in-charges. Upward: the shift’s daily production return to the manager. Horizontal: dyeing and finishing supervisors coordinating a lot’s schedule. Diagonal: the quality manager speaking directly to another department’s shift supervisor about a fault.
5. Both channels in sequence: an immediate oral apology and explanation by phone (interpersonal, fast, relationship-repairing), followed the same day by a written letter/email recording the facts and commitments for the claim file.
6. Non-verbal behaviour is continuous, largely involuntary and hard to fake consistently — listeners treat it as the leak of true feeling, while words are known to be chosen and controllable. Hence the incongruent speaker is disbelieved.
7. Group: participants both send and receive, feedback is immediate and personal, numbers are small enough for turn-taking. Mass: one sender addresses many dispersed receivers who mostly cannot reply; feedback arrives slowly and statistically (sales figures, surveys), and roles stay fixed.